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Guest editor's introduction

Rethinking the nature of change in students' knowledge and beliefs: introduction to the special issue on persuasion

In the last decade, there has been a sustained interest in the changes that individuals or groups undergo as a consequence of both formal education and everyday encounters (Pintrich, Marx, & Boyle, 1993; Vosniadou, 1994). Grasping the nature of such changes, as well as the conditions that stimulate or stifle that progression, remain keys for educators who envision their purpose as the enrichment of human understanding (Guzzetti & Hynd, 1998). Without question, the literature in conceptual change is replete with studies documenting the apparent resistance of certain conceptualizations to seemingly compelling evidence or contradictory events (Chinn & Brewer, 1993). However, there is an equally rich literature on change that has not received extensive attention in mainstream educational research and practice as that dedicated to conceptual change—that is the research on persuasion (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986; Stiff, 1994).

As with the conceptual change literature, much of the persuasion research has roots that extend deeply into early and contemporary philosophy (e.g., Cooper, 1932). Further, those engaged in persuasion and conceptual change research appear to share the goal of unraveling the mystery as to what makes some ideas or the presentation of those ideas more acceptable to some but so uninviting to others (Murphy, 1998). Yet, despite these common ends, the potential contributions of persuasion research to current educational practice have been overlooked. The purpose of this special issue is to remedy this situation by highlighting several innovative and thought-provoking studies on persuasion that advance our thinking on the change process.

Specifically, this issue builds on highlighted symposia on persuasion and conceptual change held at annual meetings of the American Educational Research Association. One of those symposia, "Seeking common ground: Exploring the bonds between conceptual change and persuasion theory and research", targeted the association between these two extensive, but independent programs of inquiry. Another, "Teaching as persuasion: A new metaphor for a new decade", examined the viability of persuasion as a framework for pedagogical interventions that enhance students' learning and development.

This special issue of the *International Journal of Educational Research* includes four papers from those highlighted symposia, as well as two commentaries by experts

in learning and development. The purpose of this issue is to update the research community on the on-going research on persuasion and to overview its implications for educational practice. Beyond their overall significance and potential contributions to the educational literature, the four works, which examine the process of change in students' knowledge and beliefs, were specifically chosen for this issue for several reasons.

First, the four papers offer a cross-domain perspective on persuasion. For example, Chapter 1 by Bradford Woods and P. Karen Murphy is a philosophical treatise on the subject of persuasion, and explores the lineage it shares with conceptual change. The philosophical roots of such important psychological questions as learner change have been too often assumed or simply overlooked in the extant literature. In contrast, the Cynthia Hynd study in Chapter 4 focuses specifically on the impact of persuasive, refutational texts on students' scientific understanding, and the place of such text in the learning environment. The Murphy article in Chapter 3 employs an expert/novice paradigm to profile the ways undergraduates and persuasion researchers read and respond to persuasive texts. Finally, in Chapter 2, Patricia Alexander, Michelle Buehl, and Christopher Sperl consider the change process as it unfolds during the reading of everyday, controversial materials.

Second, this collection of studies employs a range of both quantitative and qualitative methodologies. For instance, the studies by Alexander et al. and Murphy employ a series of multivariate procedures to reach their conclusions regarding persuasion. The Woods and Murphy piece is a review of the philosophical and psychological literatures, while Hynd uses both quantitative and qualitative techniques to frame her critique of persuasion in science classrooms.

Third, these works were selected specifically because of their provocative nature. Each articulates important questions about persuasion and its place in the educational process and addresses those questions through appropriate methodologies. The conclusions these researchers forward open the door to critical discussions on the goals of formal education and the legitimacy of stimulating changes in students' knowledge and beliefs via persuasive discourse.

Finally, our commentators, well known for their research on the change process, carry this discussion of student change forward through their specific critiques of the four studies and their general reflections on the topic of persuasion. For example, in Chapter 5, Lucia Mason not only describes the theoretical and methodological threads that weave through the four articles, but also outlines a powerful and ambitious program of research for those interested in changing students' knowledge and beliefs. In Chapter 6, Stella Vosniadou frames her response to the articles in this special issue around the provocative question of whether there is something new and important about conceptual change to be garnered from this research on persuasion. Her answer to that question is yes, and she goes on to highlight two critical areas in which conceptual change research and practice can be enhanced by the work presented in this special issue.

As the special editor, my goal was relatively straightforward. I wanted to present the reader with a collection of studies that would stimulate thinking, spark interest,

and increase understanding about current work in the area of persuasion. In short, I wanted to offer a special issue that was persuasive.

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